Scientists Find an Eyeless Snail Living in a Dark Chinese Cave

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Scientists have discovered a new kind of tiny freshwater snail living deep inside a cave in China. It is the first freshwater cave snail ever recorded in the country.

The new **species** is named Erhaia dijiang. Because it spends its whole life in darkness, it has completely lost its eyes. Its cone-shaped shell is almost see-through, its body has no color, and it has long, thin feelers called **tentacles**.

The name comes from an old Chinese book of myths called the Classic of Mountains and Seas. It tells of Di Jiang, a mountain god shown as a beast with no face. The name fits, because the snail strongly avoids light. In the lab, the snails always moved into dark spaces under rocks when light shone on them.

The snail was found in a **limestone** cave about 2,062 meters, or roughly 6,800 feet, above **sea level**. That makes it the highest cave snail ever recorded in its family. The snails live among gravel and broken rocks in water less than one meter deep, where the temperature stays near 20 degrees Celsius. Scientists watched them eat **diatoms**, which are tiny algae that grow on rocks.

The discovery, published in the journal Subterranean Biology, helps scientists learn about underground water life in East Asia, which has not been studied much.

But the researchers are worried about the snail's future. During their search in August 2025, they found only three living adults and one empty shell, and no young snails. They said its outlook is "far from optimistic."

The team is asking for more surveys of caves across China and for quick action to protect these rare animals and their fragile homes.

Word Treasure

species -- A group of living things that are alike and can have young together.

tentacles -- Long, thin, bendy body parts an animal uses to feel or grab.

limestone -- A type of rock that water can slowly dissolve, often forming caves.

diatoms -- Tiny one-celled algae that grow on rocks and in water.

sea level -- The average height of the ocean's surface, used to measure how high a place is.

Background you need

Caves are dark, quiet places, and animals that live there all the time often lose their eyes and color over many generations because they no longer need them.

Many caves form in limestone, a rock that water slowly dissolves to make tunnels and pools.

When scientists find a new species, they describe it in a scientific journal and give it a two-part scientific name.

Animals that live in only one small place, like a single cave, can be at special risk because any change to that place affects the whole population.

Break it down

LEAD: Scientists discover a new freshwater cave snail, the first ever recorded in China
KEY FEATURES: Erhaia dijiang has no eyes, a nearly see-through shell, no body color and long tentacles
NAME: Honors Di Jiang, a faceless mountain god in the Classic of Mountains and Seas
HABITAT: A limestone cave about 2,062 meters high
+- WATER: Less than one meter deep, near 20°C
+- FOOD: Diatoms growing on rocks
PUBLISHED IN: The journal Subterranean Biology
CONCERN: Only three living adults and one empty shell found, no young
OPEN QUESTION: Can protections be created before the species is threatened?

Why it matters

Discovering a species that may already be very rare shows how much is still unknown about underground ecosystems and why scientists want to protect them before species disappear.

Test what you remember

1. What makes this snail discovery a first for China?

(A) It is the first snail that can fly
(B) It is the first freshwater cave snail recorded in China
(C) It is the first snail found in the ocean
(D) It is the largest snail ever found

2. Why does the snail have no eyes?

(A) It lives in complete darkness
(B) It lost them in a fight
(C) Scientists removed them
(D) It is still a baby

3. Where does the name dijiang come from?

(A) A river in China
(B) The color of its shell
(C) A faceless mountain god from an ancient Chinese book
(D) A famous scientist

4. What did the snails do when light shone on them in the lab?

(A) Hid in dark spaces under rocks
(B) Stopped moving forever
(C) Changed color
(D) Swam toward it

5. What did scientists see the snails eat?

(A) Leaves
(B) Small fish
(C) Insects
(D) Diatoms

6. How many living adult snails did researchers find?

(A) Three
(B) Three hundred
(C) None
(D) Thirty

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. The research team: Describes the snail's conservation outlook as "far from optimistic" and calls for more cave surveys and quick protections.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):